

LECTURE 5

Writing Persuasive & Positive Message

MASTERING THE
ART OF **PERSUASIVE**
COMMUNICATION



EMBA 501

Business Communication

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Learning Objectives:

1. Outline an effective strategy for writing routine business requests.
2. Describe three common types of routine requests.
3. Outline an effective strategy for writing routine replies and positive messages.
4. Describe six common types of routine replies and positive messages.

Strategy for Routine Requests

- ~ Making requests—for information, action, products, adjustments, or other matters—is a routine part of business.
- ~ In most cases, your audience will be prepared to comply, as long as you're not being unreasonable or asking people to do work, they would expect you to do yourself.
- ~ By applying a clear strategy and tailoring your approach to each situation, you'll be able to generate effective requests quickly.
- ~ Like all other business messages, **routine requests have three parts:**

Three Parts (Direct Approach)

- (1) **The Opening:** Open with the main idea, which is a clear statement of your request.
- (2) **The Body:** Use the body to give details and justify your request.
- (3) **The Close:** Close by requesting specific action.

Opening: Stating Your Request Up Front

~ **Begin routine requests by placing your initial request first**; up front is where it stands out and gets the most attention. Of course, getting right to the point should not be interpreted as license to be abrupt or tactless.

1. **Pay attention to tone.** Instead of demanding action, soften your request with words such as please and I would appreciate.
2. **Assume that your audience will comply.** You can generally make the assumption that your audience members will comply when they clearly understand the reason for your request.
3. **Be specific.** State precisely what you want. For example, if you request the latest market data from your research department, be sure to say whether you want a one-page summary or 100 pages of raw data.

Body: Explaining and Justifying Your Request

~ **Use the body of your message to explain your request**, as needed. Make the explanation a smooth and logical outgrowth of your opening remarks:

- If complying with the **request could benefit the reader, be sure to mention that.**
- If you have **multiple requests or questions, ask the most important questions first** and deal with only one topic per question.
- If you have an **unusual or complex request, break it down into specific, individual questions** so that the reader can address each one separately.

These considerations not only shows respect for your audience's time but also gets you a more accurate answer in less time.

Close: Requesting Specific Action in a Courteous Close

~ Close your message with three important elements:

1. **A specific request that includes any specific deadlines**
2. **Information about how you can be reached**
3. **An expression of appreciation or goodwill**

~ **Conclude your message by sincerely expressing your goodwill and appreciation.**

~ When you ask readers to perform a specific action, **ask for a response by a specific date or time, if appropriate.**

~ However, **don't thank the reader "in advance"** for cooperating; many people find that presumptuous. And if the reader's reply warrants a word of thanks, send it after you've received the reply.

Common Examples of Routine Requests

~ Most of the routine messages that you'll be writing will likely fall into a few main categories:

1. **Asking for information and action**
2. **Asking for recommendations**
3. **Making claims and requesting adjustments**

Asking for Information and Action

1. **State your request clearly**
2. **Explain and support the request**
3. **Introduce reader benefits**

Asking for Recommendations

1. **State your request clearly**
2. **Offer support for your request**
3. **Express your appreciation**

Making Claims and Requesting Adjustments

1. **State the problem clearly**
2. **Explain the situation clearly**
3. **Request specific action**

Asking for recommendations

Tucker includes information near the opening to refresh her professor's memory.

She provides a deadline for response and includes information about the person who is expecting the recommendation.

1181 Ashport Drive
Tate Springs, TN 38101
March 14, 2021

Professor Lyndon Kenton
School of Business
University of Tennessee, Knoxville
Knoxville, TN 37916

Dear Professor Kenton:

I recently interviewed with Strategic Investments and have been called for a second interview for their Analyst Training Program (ATP). They have requested at least one recommendation from a professor, and I immediately thought of you. May I have a letter of recommendation from you?

As you may recall, I took FINC 425, Investment and Portfolio Management, from you during the Fall 2020 semester. I was fascinated by the methods of risk and return analysis you presented, and the class confirmed my decision to pursue a career in investment management.

My enclosed résumé includes all my relevant work experience and volunteer activities. I would also like to add that I've handled the financial planning for our family since my father passed away several years ago, and I have increasingly applied my business training in deciding what stocks or bonds to trade. This, I believe, has given me a practical edge over others who may be applying for the same job.

If possible, Ms. Blackmon in Human Resources needs to receive your letter by March 30. For your convenience, I've enclosed a preaddressed, stamped envelope.

I appreciate your time and effort in writing this letter of recommendation for me. It will be great to put my education to work, and I'll keep you informed of my progress. Thank you for your consideration in this matter.

Sincerely,

Joanne Tucker

Joanne Tucker

Enclosure

← The opening states the purpose of the letter and makes the request, assuming the reader will want to comply.

← The body refers to the enclosed résumé and mentions experience that could set the applicant apart from other candidates—information the professor could use in writing the recommendation.

← The close is warm and respectful.

Strategy for Routine Replies

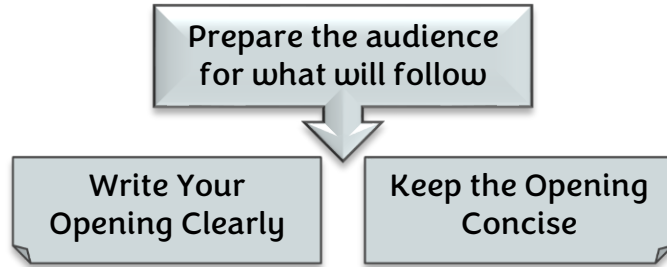
~ Just as you'll make numerous requests for information and action throughout your career, you'll also respond to similar requests from other people.

~ When you are **responding positively to a request**, sending routine announcements, or sending a positive or goodwill message, **you have several goals:**

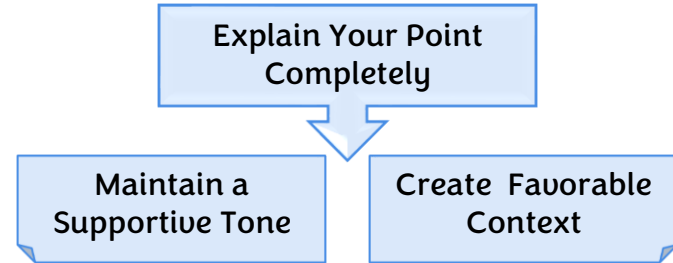
- i. **Communicate the information or the good news**
- ii. **Answer all questions**
- iii. **Provide all required details**
- iv. **Leave your reader with a good impression of you and your firm**

Strategy for Routine Replies

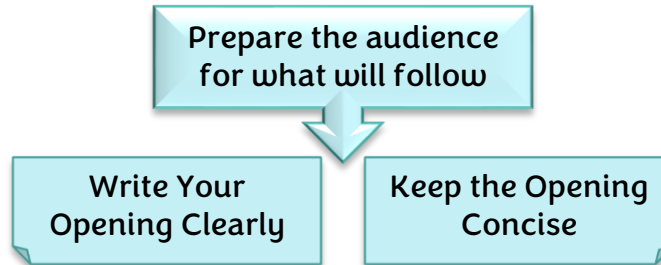
1. Starting with the Main Idea



2. Providing Necessary Details and Explanation



3. Ending with a Courteous Close



Strategy for Routine Replies

1. **By opening your routine and positive messages with the main idea** or good news, you're preparing your audience for the details that follow. Make your opening clear and concise by asking yourself, "What's the single most important message that I have for the audience?"
2. **In the body of your message, explain your point completely** so that your audience won't be confused or doubtful about your meaning. In addition, maintain the supportive tone established in the opening—even if you must convey mildly disappointing information. If your routine message is mixed and must convey mildly disappointing information, put the negative information into as favorable a context as possible.
3. **The close of routine replies and positive messages is usually short and simple**, because you're leaving things on a neutral or positive note and not usually asking the reader to do anything. Often, a simple thank you is all you need. However, if follow-up action is required or expected, use the close to identify who will do what and when that action will take place.

Common Examples for Routine Replies

~ Most routine and positive messages fall into seven categories:

1. Answers to requests for information and action:

~ If your answer to a request is “yes” or is straightforward information, use the direct plan. Open with the main idea (or good news), use the body for explanation and detail, and close courteously. Your prompt, gracious, and thorough response will positively influence how people think about your company, its products, your department, and you.

2. Grants of claims and requests for adjustment:

~ Even the best-run companies make mistakes. Each of these events represents a turning point in your relationship with your customer. In other words, every mistake is an opportunity to improve a relationship.

~ How you respond to the complaint depends on your company’s policies for resolving such issues and your assessment of whether the company, the customer, or a third party is at fault.

Common Examples for Routine Replies

~ In general, take the following steps to solve claims:

- a. Acknowledge receipt of the customer's claim or complaint.
- b. Sympathize with the customer's inconvenience or frustration.
- c. Take (or assign) personal responsibility for setting matters straight.
- d. Explain precisely how you have resolved, or plan to resolve, the situation.
- e. Take steps to repair the relationship.
- f. Follow up to verify that your response was correct.

~ In addition to taking these positive steps, maintain a professional demeanor. Don't blame colleagues by name; don't make exaggerated, insincere apologies; don't imply that the customer is at fault; and don't promise more than you can deliver.

Common Examples for Routine Replies

3. Recommendations and References.

~ If you decide to write a **letter of recommendation** or respond to a request for information about a job candidate, **your goal is to convince readers that the person being recommended has the characteristics necessary** for the job, project assignment, or other objective the person is seeking.

~ A successful recommendation letter contains a number of relevant details:

- **The candidate's full name**
- **The position or other objective the candidate is seeking**
- **The nature of your relationship with the candidate**
- **Facts and evidence relevant to the candidate and the opportunity**
- **A comparison of the candidate's potential with that of peers, if available**
- **Your overall evaluation of the candidate's suitability for the opportunity**

Common Examples for Routine Replies

4. Sharing Routine Information.

- ~ All companies send routine informative messages, such as project updates and order status notifications.
- ~ In the opening, state your purpose and briefly mention the nature of the information you're providing.
- ~ Provide necessary details in the body and then end your message with a courteous close.
- ~ **Some routine informative messages may require additional care.** For instance, policy statements or procedural changes may be good news for a company (perhaps by saving money).
- ~ **However, if the reader may not initially view the information positively, use the body of the message to highlight the potential benefits from the reader's perspective.**
- ~ **For situations in which negative news will have a profound effect on the recipients, consider the indirect techniques.**

Common Examples for Routine Replies

5. Writing Instructions.

~ **Follow these steps to create clear and effective instructions on any topic:**

- i. Make sure you understand how much your readers know about the subject.
- ii. Provide an overview of the procedure. Explain what users will be doing, and identify any information or tools they will need to complete the procedure.
- iii. Define any technical terms or acronyms that readers need to understand.
- iv. Divide the procedure into discrete steps, with each step focusing on a single task.
- v. Tell readers what to expect when they complete each step, so they know they've done it correctly (for example, "If the green LED is on, you've made a secure connection").
- vi. Test the instructions on someone from the target audience.
- vii. Whenever possible, provide a way for readers to ask for help.

Common Examples for Routine Replies

6. **Announcing Good News.**

- To develop and maintain good relationships, smart companies recognize that it's good business to **spread the word about positive developments.**
- Such developments can include opening new facilities, hiring a new executive, introducing new products or services, or sponsoring community events.
- **Because good news is always welcome, use the direct approach.**
- **External good-news announcements** are often communicated in a news release, also known as a **press release**, a specialized document used to share relevant information with the news media.

Common Examples for Routine Replies

7. **Fostering Goodwill.**

~ While all business messages should promote positive relationships with audiences, some messages are written specifically to build goodwill.

~ **You can enhance your relationships with customers, colleagues, and others by sending friendly, even unexpected, notes with no direct business purpose.**

1. One prime opportunity for sending goodwill messages is to **congratulate someone** for a significant business achievement. Other reasons for sending congratulations include recognizing the highlights in someone's life.
2. It is important to recognize the **contributions of employees, colleagues, suppliers, and other associates**. Moreover, a message of appreciation may become an important part of someone's personnel file. So, when you write a message of appreciation, mention the person or people you want to praise.
3. **Condolence letters** are brief, personal messages written to comfort someone after the death of a loved one.

THE END.

